

Troop 500G Handbook

Scouting America Troop 500G, Solon, Ohio

Lake Erie Council

April 2026

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Welcome to the official handbook for Scouting America Troop 500G. This handbook serves as your comprehensive guide to troop operations, policies, procedures, and resources.

Last Updated: {{ site.time | date: "%B %Y" }}

For questions about this handbook, contact the Scoutmaster or visit us at our weekly meetings.

1 About Troop 500G

Troop 500G is a female Scouting America troop operating out of Solon, Ohio, serving the youth of Northeast Ohio. We are a proud part of the Lake Erie Council and are chartered by Advent Lutheran Church.

1.1 Our Mission

To provide girls with opportunities to develop leadership skills, experience outdoor adventures, serve their community, and advance toward Eagle Scout while building lifelong friendships.

1.2 Meeting Information

- **Regular Meetings:** Monday evenings, 7:00-8:30 PM at Advent Lutheran Church, Solon, OH
 - **Summer Schedule:** Monday evenings, 6:30-8:00 PM at South Chagrin Reservation Shelterhouse
- Check the events calendar for current meeting times and locations.*

1.3 Scouting America's Foundation

Understanding Scouting America's mission and methods helps families appreciate the comprehensive youth development program your Scout will experience.

1.3.0.1 Mission Statement The mission of Scouting America is to prepare young people to make ethical and moral choices over their lifetimes by instilling in them the values of the Scout Oath and Law.

1.3.0.2 Vision Statement Scouting America will prepare every eligible youth in America to become a responsible, participating citizen and leader who is guided by the Scout Oath and Law.

1.3.1 The Scout Oath

On my honor I will do my best To do my duty to God and my country and to obey the Scout Law; To help other people at all times; To keep myself physically strong, mentally awake, and morally straight.

1.3.2 The Scout Law

A Scout Is: Trustworthy, Loyal, Helpful, Friendly, Courteous, Kind, Obedient, Cheerful, Thrifty, Brave, Clean, Reverent

1.3.3 Scouting's Aims and Methods

Scouting achieves its mission through four main aims: **character development**, **leadership development**, **citizenship training**, and **personal fitness**. These are accomplished through eight interconnected methods:

1. **Ideals** - Living by the Scout Oath, Law, motto, and slogan
2. **Patrols** - Small group experiences that teach responsibility and citizenship
3. **Outdoor Programs** - Learning through nature and outdoor adventures
4. **Advancement** - Progressive challenges that build self-confidence and skills
5. **Association with Adults** - Positive role modeling and mentoring relationships
6. **Personal Growth** - Individual development through service and reflection
7. **Leadership Development** - Learning and practicing leadership skills
8. **Uniform** - Visible commitment to Scouting ideals and community service

More information: Scouting's Aims and Methods

1.4 Our Charter Organization

Advent Lutheran Church

5525 Harper Road

Solon, OH 44139

Phone: (440) 248-6904

Website: adventsolon.org

Location Map: Visit Google Maps: Advent Lutheran Church, 5525 Harper Road, Solon, OH

We are grateful for the support and partnership of Advent Lutheran Church, which provides us with meeting space and organizational support.

1.5 Lake Erie Council



Lake Erie Council, BSA

Troop 500G is proudly chartered through the Lake Erie Council, which serves Scouts across Northeast Ohio. The Lake Erie Council provides training, resources, and support to help units deliver high-quality Scouting programs that build character, citizenship, and fitness in young people.

Contact Information:

Cleveland, OH 44115

Email: LECMemberCare@scouting.org

Website: lecscouting.org

PO Box 93388

Cleveland, OH 44101-5388

Troop 500G operates under the Scouting America troop leadership model, where youth leaders are elected by the troop and adult leaders provide guidance and support to all youth-led activities.

A Scout patrol is a small team of normally six to eight members where Scouts learn skills together, share responsibilities and take on leadership roles. Each patrol elects its own patrol leader and develops its own identity and traditions.

For more information about the patrol method, see the Scouting America Patrol Method Guide.

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1.7.1 Senior Patrol Leader (SPL)

The highest youth leadership position, elected by the troop, the senior patrol leader is one of the oldest leadership positions in Scouting. Scouting America has long recognized the senior patrol leader as the highest youth leadership position in a troop. They are the primary link between a troop's Scouts and its adult leaders. They shoulder the responsibility for leading meetings of the troop and the patrol leaders' council and provide valuable leadership in planning and carrying out the troop's program of outdoor activities, service projects, and events.

Senior Patrol Leader Responsibilities: - Runs all troop meetings, events, activities, and the annual program planning conference - Runs the patrol leaders' council (PLC) meetings - Appoints other troop youth leaders with the advice and counsel of the Scoutmaster - Assigns duties and responsibilities to youth leaders - Assists the Scoutmaster with youth leader training - Sets a good example - Wears the Scout uniform correctly - Lives by the Scout Oath and Law - Shows Scout spirit

For more information about the Senior Patrol Leader role, see the Scouting America Senior Patrol Leader Guide and refer to Scouting America Publication *Senior Patrol Leader Handbook*.



1.7.2 Patrol Leaders

Lead individual patrols, elected by patrol members. The patrol leader is the patrol's key leader, representing the patrol at all patrol leaders' council meetings and the annual program planning conference, and keeping patrol members informed of decisions made. Patrol leaders carry out planning, leading, and evaluating patrol meetings and activities, and assure patrols are prepared to participate in all troop activities. They keep their patrol intact so they can work together and share responsibilities to get things done. It is incumbent upon them to be a good example for the members of their patrol and the rest of the troop.

Patrol Leader Responsibilities: - Plans and leads patrol meetings and activities - Keeps patrol members informed - Assigns each patrol member a specific duty - Represents his patrol at all patrol leaders' council meetings and the annual program planning conference - Prepares the patrol to participate in all troop activities - Works with other troop leaders to make the troop run well - Knows the abilities of each patrol member - Sets a good example - Wears the Scout uniform correctly - Lives by the Scout Oath and Law - Shows and develops patrol spirit

For more information about the Patrol Leader role, see the Scouting America Patrol Leader Guide and refer to Scouting America Publication *The Patrol Leader Handbook*.



1.7.3 Quartermaster

Quartermasters serve as the troop's supply boss. They keep an inventory of troop equipment and see that the gear is in good condition. They work with patrol quartermasters as they check out equipment and return it. At meetings of the patrol leaders' council they report on the status of equipment in need of replacement or repair. In carrying out their responsibilities, they may have the guidance of a member of the troop committee.

Quartermaster Responsibilities: - Keeps records on patrol and troop equipment - Makes sure equipment is in good working condition - Issues equipment and makes sure it is returned in good condition - Makes suggestions for new or replacement items - Works with the troop committee member responsible for equipment - Sets a good example - Wears the Scout uniform correctly - Lives by the Scout Oath and Law - Shows Scout spirit

For more information about the Quartermaster role, see the Scouting America Quartermaster Guide.



1.7.4 Scribe

The scribe is the troop's secretary. Though not a voting member, they attend meetings of the patrol leaders' council and keep a record of the discussions. They cooperate with the patrol scribes to record attendance at troop meetings and to maintain troop advancement records. The troop scribe may be assisted by a member of the troop committee.

Scribe Responsibilities: - Attends and keeps a log of patrol leaders' council meetings - Records individual Scout attendance - Records individual Scout advancement progress - Works with the troop committee member responsible for records and finance - Sets a good example - Wears the Scout uniform correctly - Lives by the Scout Oath and Law - Shows Scout spirit

For more information about the Scribe role, see the Scouting America Scribe Guide.

Other Troop Positions: Additional leadership positions available

1.8 Adult Leadership



1.8.1 Scoutmaster

The Scoutmaster is the adult responsible for working directly with the Scouts providing direction, coaching, and support.

The Scoutmaster has three basic roles: - Providing the youth leaders with the tools and skills so they can run the troop - Making sure the rules of Scouting America and chartered partner are followed - Being a

good mentor and positive role model

For more information about the Scoutmaster role, see the Scouting America Scoutmaster Guide.

More Resources: - Every youth deserves a trained leader. See more about training opportunities for adults including Scoutmasters - BSA Publication *Troop Leader Guidebook*



1.8.2 Assistant Scoutmaster

Available position. An assistant Scoutmaster is an adult leader over the age of 18 who helps the Scoutmaster deliver the promise of Scouting. Each assistant Scoutmaster is assigned specific program duties. They can serve the troop by guiding a particular patrol to which they've been assigned, advising certain Scouts who've assumed a position e.g. the quartermaster or OA representative, or fill in as necessary to assure the junior leaders have what they need to run things.

They also provide the two-deep leadership required by Scouting America. An assistant Scoutmaster may be 18 years old, but at least one in each troop should be 21 or older so they can serve in the Scoutmaster's absence.

For more information about the Assistant Scoutmaster role, see the Scouting America Assistant Scoutmaster Guide.



1.8.3 Chartered Organization Representative

Available position. The Chartered Organization Representative (COR) is the direct contact between the unit and the Chartered Organization. This individual is also the organization's contact with the District Committee and the Local Council. The chartered organization representative may become a member of the district committee and is a voting member of the council. If the chartered organization has more than one unit, one representative serves them all. The Chartered Organization Representative appoints the Unit Committee Chairman.

For more information about the Chartered Organization Representative role, see the Scouting America Chartered Organization Representative Guide and the Chartered Organization Representative Position Description.

For detailed information about all adult leadership positions and responsibilities, see the Scouting America Troop Structure Guide.

1.9 Troop 500G Committee

The troop committee is a cross between a board of directors and a parent support group. It sets troop policies and handles administrative functions, allowing the Scoutmaster and assistant Scoutmasters to focus on working directly with the Scouts.

A robust troop committee supports an effective scouting program. The below is a list of common and desirable roles for adults within the troop committee.



1.9.1 Committee Chair

Available position

The troop committee chair is appointed by the chartered organization to see that all committee functions are carried out. The troop committee chair appoints and supervises the unit committee and unit leaders, and organizes the committee to see that all committee responsibilities are delegated, coordinated and completed.

Committee Chair Duties: - Organize the committee to see that all functions are delegated, coordinated, and completed - Maintain a close relationship with the chartered organization representative and the Scoutmaster - Interpret national and local policies to the troop - Prepare troop committee meeting agendas - Call, preside over, and promote attendance at monthly troop committee meetings and any special meetings that may be called - Ensure troop representation at roundtables - Secure top-notch, trained individuals for camp leadership - Arrange for charter review and recharter annually - Plan the charter presentation

For more information about the Committee Chair role, see the Scouting America Committee Chairman Guide.

1.9.2 Secretary

Duties: - Keep minutes of meeting and send out committee meeting notices - Handle publicity - Prepare a family newsletter of troop events and activities - Conduct troop resource survey - Plan for family night programs and family activities - At each meeting, report the minutes of the previous meeting

1.9.3 Treasurer

Duties: - Handle all troop funds. Pay bills on recommendation of the Scoutmaster and authorization of the troop committee - Maintain checking and/or savings accounts - Train and supervise the troop scribe in record keeping - Keep adequate records - Supervise money-earning projects, including obtaining proper authorizations - Supervise the camp savings plan - Lead in the preparation of the annual troop budget - Lead the Friends of Scouting campaign - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

1.9.4 Outdoor Activities Coordinator

Duties: - Help in securing permission to use camping sites - Serve as transportation coordinator - Ensure a monthly outdoor program - Promote the National Camping Award - Promote, through family meetings, attendance at troop campouts, camporees, and summer camp to reach the goal of an outing per month - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

1.9.5 Advancement Coordinator

Duties: - Encourage Scouts to advance in rank - Work with the troop scribe to maintain all Scout advancement records - Arrange quarterly troop boards of review and courts of honor - Recruit merit badge counselors - Make a prompt report of advancements using online tools or appropriate paper forms to the

council service center. Secure badges and certificates - Work with the troop librarian to build and maintain a troop library of merit badge pamphlets and other advancement literature - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

1.9.6 Chaplain

Duties: - Provide a spiritual tone for troop meetings and activities - Give guidance to the chaplain aide - Promote regular participation of each member in the activities of the religious organization of their choice - Encourage Scouts to earn their appropriate religious emblems - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

1.9.7 Training Coordinator

Duties: - Ensure troop leaders and committee members have opportunities for training - Maintain an inventory of up-to-date training materials and resources - Be responsible for Youth Protection Training compliance within the troop - Encourage periodic youth leadership training within the troop and at the council and national levels - Report to the troop committee at each meeting - Assist in orientation to new parents - Be watchful that the troop is taking all steps to ensure youth safety

1.9.8 Equipment Coordinator

Duties: - Supervise and help the troop procure camping equipment - Work with the quartermaster on inventory and proper storage and maintenance of all troop equipment - Make periodic safety checks on all troop camping gear, and encourage the troop in the safe use of all outdoor equipment - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

1.9.9 Membership Coordinator

Duties: - Develop a plan for year-round membership flow into the troop - Work closely with the Cubmaster and Webelos/AOL den leaders of neighboring Cub Scout packs to provide a smooth transition from pack to troop. Assist in developing and recruiting den chiefs, and assist in the crossover ceremony - Plan and coordinate troop open houses to invite non-Scouts into the troop - Encourage Scouts to invite their friends to the troop - Keep track of Scouts who drop out of the troop, and develop a plan to encourage them to rejoin - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

This is not an exhaustive list of positions a troop may need. Troops are encouraged to engage all parents in a role that suits their skills and interests.

The essential support literature for troop committee members is the Scouting America publication *Scouts BSA Troop Committee Guidebook*.

2 Parents Guide

Welcome to Scouting America Troop 500G! We are happy to have you and your daughter join us for the awesome adventure of Scouting!

Scouting is a new experience for both scout and parent. There is a time when the parents, although still involved in new ways, take a step back and let their daughters take on more and more responsibility for their achievements. While Scouting is girl-led, it is parent-facilitated. Your role as a facilitator requires a

commitment of your time on both organizational and activity levels. This guide provides what a parent needs to know to survive the first year of scout life.

2.1 Your First Meeting

We meet Monday evenings at Advent Lutheran Church (regular meetings 7:00-8:30 PM, summer meetings 6:30-8:00 PM). All activities are tracked in Scoutbook and Google Calendar, and we organize monthly outings for advancement and merit badges.

You may not have everything we list as required when you start - don't worry! Do your best, show up ready to learn about Scouting, and we'll work with you on the rest. More detailed information about meetings and activities can be found later in the handbook.

2.2 Troop Communications

We use GroupMe for routine chats following all Youth Protection Training two-deep policies. We have groups for the troop, committee, parents, and each patrol, as well as groups for specific events as needed. We use Scoutbook as much as possible to keep all information in one place. Adult leaders also use a Google Drive, but we are working to move as much information as possible onto the website troop500.org to reduce the number of locations we need to access.

2.3 Joining Conference

Every new Scout family is required to participate in a joining conference with troop leadership before their Scout's first overnight camping experience. This friendly, informative meeting helps us understand your Scout's unique strengths, interests, and any special considerations that will help ensure their success in our program.

The joining conference is scheduled within the first month after joining and serves as an important step in creating a supportive environment where every Scout can thrive. During the conference, we'll discuss how we can work together as partners to provide the best possible Scouting experience and establish open communication.

For detailed information about what to expect and how to prepare, see our comprehensive Conference Communications section.

2.4 Documents, Sites and Training

Getting started with Troop 500 involves a few important steps to keep everyone safe and connected. You'll need to complete some paperwork, get familiar with our digital tools, and take care of some training requirements. Don't worry - we'll walk you through everything! Here's what you and your Scout need to take care of within your first month, and definitely before your Scout's first campout.

Register with Scouting America If you haven't already registered with Scouting America, visit BeAScout.scouting.org which will walk you through the registration process as well as provide resources for finding other Scouting units around us.

My.Scouting.org My.Scouting.org is where you'll create your Scouting America account, complete training requirements like Safeguarding Youth, and manage your annual membership renewal. This is your central hub for all official Scouting America business and training.

Scoutbook Every Scout, adult leader, and parent/guardian should have a Scoutbook account. Scoutbook uses your My.Scouting.org account and is the official digital platform for Scouting America that tracks advancement, activities, and communication. Your Scout's progress, merit badge requirements, and troop calendar are all managed through Scoutbook. Parents and Scouts can access Scoutbook through the web at scoutbook.scouting.org or via the mobile app.

For help getting started with Scoutbook, download the Parents Trail Guide to Scoutbook.

Guide to Safe Scouting All participants in official Scouting activities should become familiar with the Guide to Safe Scouting and applicable program literature or manuals, and be aware of state or local government regulations that supersede Scouting America practices, policies, and guidelines. The Guide to Safe Scouting is an overview of Scouting policies and procedures gleaned from a variety sources.

Guide to Safe Scouting: <https://www.scouting.org/health-and-safety/gss/>

Annual Health and Medical Record For any and all Scouting activities, all participants must complete Part A and Part B of the Annual Health and Medical Record. "All participants" includes parents, guardians, siblings, youth, staff, and unit leaders. Part C (pre-participation physical by a licensed health-care provider) is required for events lasting longer than 72 hours, such as summer camp or high adventure activities, though all participants are encouraged to complete this during an annual exam.

Forms are available at: Scouting America Annual Health and Medical Record

Troop Website Our troop website at troop500.org contains the most up-to-date information about our troop, including this handbook, meeting schedules, upcoming events, resources, and important announcements. We encourage all families to bookmark and regularly check the website for the latest information.

Social Media Waiver Troop 500G occasionally takes photos and videos during meetings, events, and outings for promotional purposes, social media posts, and documentation of activities. The Social Media Waiver allows families to specify their preferences regarding photography and the use of their Scout's image in troop communications and social media. This form ensures we respect each family's privacy wishes while still being able to share the great experiences and achievements of our troop.

Download: Troop 500 Social Media Waiver

Safeguarding Youth Safeguarding Youth training is required for all Scouting America registered volunteers and is a joining requirement that must be renewed annually. If training is not current at registration renewal, the volunteer will not be re-registered. This training is strongly encouraged for parents and guardians, and is required for any adult attending longer campouts (72+ hours) like summer resident camp.

More information: <https://www.scouting.org/training/youth-protection/>

2.5 Gear Up

As an organization focused on a wide variety of activities, it is easy to either overspend on gear or become overwhelmed by everything you think you need. A Scout is thrifty - please do not buy everything you think you'll need for your entire Scouting experience before your first meeting. The gear listed below consists of the basics that you need to get started. The troop also has access to some secondhand uniform items and can provide recommendations on the best way to gear up.

2.5.1 Scout Handbook

Required for all advancement (*provided for new Scouts joining our troop*)

2.5.2 Class A Uniform (Field Uniform)

The Class A uniform is purchased individually at the Scout Shop with some components provided by the troop.

2.5.3 Class B Uniform (Activity Uniform)

The Class B uniform is purchased from the troop during your first couple of meetings.

2.5.4 Scout 10 Essentials

Learn more about the 10 Essentials

“Prepared. For Life.” It’s more than a motto for Scouting; it’s a way to plan and execute each outing, even if it’s just a Saturday morning hike. In the woods, the items here (stowed in a daypack) can keep you comfortable, warm, hydrated, safe and, most of all, prepared to face what nature puts in your path — whether you asked for it or not.

1. Pocket Knife
2. First Aid Kit
3. Extra Clothing
4. Rain Gear
5. Water Storage
6. Flashlight / Headlamp
7. Trail Food
8. Matches / Fire Starters
9. Sun Protection
10. Map / Compass

Note: Camping gear will be discussed separately as you prepare for your first outing. The troop provides tents and cooking equipment.

2.6 Troop Fees and Expenses

Annual Membership Fees All Scouts and adult leaders must complete annual membership renewal through My.Scouting.org. This includes both Scouting America registration fees and troop dues.

Event Fees Event fees are collected by the troop Treasurer and tracked in your Scout’s Scoutbook account.

2.7 Getting Involved

While Scouting America is youth-led, it requires dedicated adult volunteers who undergo comprehensive training in youth protection, position-specific skills, advanced leadership development, and event/safety-specific training. We encourage any and all parents to become trained leaders, but we also realize that not everyone has the capacity in their lives at this time to take on formal leadership roles.

2.8 Support Your Scout

The best way to get involved is by helping your Scout do their best in the Scouting program. Remember, help and support does not mean do it for them. A key tenet of Scouting is to develop independent and capable leaders. As Lord Baden-Powell said, “Never do for a Scout what they can do for themselves.”

Every Scout develops on their own timeline, and the level of support needed varies from Scout to Scout and changes over time. Some Scouts may need more guidance with organization and reminders, while others quickly become self-directed. What works for one Scout may not work for another, and that’s completely normal! Talk to Scout leaders and other parents to learn more about everyone’s Scouting journey - their experiences can provide valuable insights into supporting your own Scout’s growth and development.

Here are ways to support your Scout’s success: - Remind them to follow communications and schedules by reviewing Scoutbook and troop announcements together - Assist with getting their uniform together and ensuring they have required gear - Encourage them to take ownership of their advancement and merit badge progress - Support their leadership development by letting them solve problems and make decisions - Communicate with adult leaders about accessibility options or special considerations that help our leaders better understand how to work with and support your Scout along their Scouting journey - Be available for transportation when they need to attend meetings and activities - Help with setup and cleanup at events while letting your Scout take the lead on their responsibilities

Advocate for Your Scout’s Needs Our troop provides an accessible and inclusive environment for every eligible youth. We will always do our best to support your scouts needs, but you can help our best be better. We require a joining meeting prior to your Scout’s first overnight outing, but that’s not the end of our discussion. You are encouraged to request a pre-event check-in with leaders attending any event (particularly helpful for summer camp) to ensure we can provide the best possible support for your Scout’s success.

2.9 Learn About the Troop

There’s a lot to learn about Scouting in general and our troop specifically! Whether you’re completely new to Scouting or earned your Eagle Scout rank back in the day, the program is always evolving. New families need time to understand how everything works, and even experienced Scouting parents find that each troop has its own culture and way of doing things. We encourage you to take time to observe and learn before jumping into formal roles.

Attending Weekly Meetings Parents are welcome to attend weekly meetings to learn about the troop! During meetings, Scouts and Scoutmasters will break away for dedicated skills instruction and Scout-led activities. While parents are ALWAYS welcome to observe, remember that Scouting is Scout-led and we encourage you to give your Scout room to learn and grow independently. Sometimes that means we’ll let mistakes happen and allow interactions to play out naturally - our job is to create a safe and inclusive environment where Scouts can grow and learn from their experiences.

Please note that any direct contact volunteer leaders (those working directly with Scouts) are required to have completed Safeguarding Youth training before participating in Scouting activities.

What Parents Can Do During Troop Meetings: - Get to know the committee members and other parents, help us build our troop community - Learn about upcoming events - Take on “service in a snap” tasks that help the troop function - Complete online training modules on your phone or device - Go on a

grocery run! Life's busy and you don't have to attend every meeting unless you want to.

Parent Meetings and Committee Meetings - Attend monthly parent meetings to stay informed about troop activities and decisions - Join committee meetings to participate in planning and troop business - These meetings are great opportunities to ask questions and connect with other parents and leaders

2.10 Support Your Troop

How can I help?

As volunteer adult leaders, we try to ask for help when we need it, but honestly, sometimes we don't get around to it or forget to mention it. If you have a little time and want to pitch in, we'd love to have you help! Come to our committee meetings, show up to parent meetings, or just ask any committee member how you can help. There's always more work than hands to do it, and any help is genuinely appreciated.

2.10.1 Supporting Troop Events and Activities

The simplest way to start getting involved is by providing minimal support for troop events and activities. These contributions are invaluable and help our troop function smoothly:

- **Transportation:** Drive Scouts to meetings/events, assist with carpooling, and help transport equipment
- **Event Support:** Help with setup/cleanup at activities, assist with simple tasks, and support special events
- **Equipment Care:** Help maintain and organize troop gear, assist with inventory, and support equipment management

These activities typically require Safeguarding Youth Training and provide a great way to see how the troop operates while making meaningful contributions.

2.11 Take Some Training

2.11.1 Safeguarding Youth Training

Safeguarding Youth training is required for all registered adult leaders and strongly encouraged for all parents and guardians. This training helps new members understand the requirements behind every decision we make in Scouting America. Available online at my.scouting.org, this training covers child abuse prevention and safe Scouting practices and must be renewed every three years.

2.11.2 Online Training

My.Scouting.org offers various online training modules that can help you better understand Scouting and support your Scout's experience. These courses are available at your own pace and can help you feel more confident when participating in troop activities.

2.11.3 In-Person Training

See the Leaders Guide for details on in-person and advanced training offered through Lake Erie Council and Scouting America.

3 Advancement Guide

Scouting America advancement provides a progressive series of challenges that help Scouts develop skills, confidence, and leadership. Scouts can work on any requirement for advancement or merit badges at any time, but can only advance a rank when ALL requirements for that rank are completed. Rank advancement is earned — it is not automatic.

3.1 Advancement to Scout

Welcome to your Scouting adventure! Your Scout rank is your introduction to Scouting and the foundation for everything that follows. This rank should be completed within your first month and teaches you the fundamentals you need to participate fully in troop activities.

3.1.1 Your First 30 Days: What to Expect

Starting Scouting is an exciting adventure! Here's what you can expect during your first month as you work toward earning your Scout rank.

3.1.2 Your First Meeting Experience

When you walk into your first troop meeting, you'll be welcomed by your new Scout family:

Meeting Your Patrol - You'll be assigned to a patrol - your small group of fellow Scouts - Your patrol leader (an experienced Scout) will help guide you through your first meetings - Patrol members will become some of your closest friends in Scouting - You'll participate in patrol activities, games, and skill-building exercises

Learning the Basics - Practice the Scout Oath, Law, Motto, and Slogan - Learn the Scout sign, salute, and handshake - Understand how the patrol method works - Get familiar with your Scout handbook - Start working on basic knots and skills

3.1.3 Scout Rank Requirements

Your Scout rank covers the essential knowledge every Scout needs. Here's what you'll learn and demonstrate:

Scouting Knowledge - Scout Oath, Law, Motto, and Slogan: Learn these by heart and explain what they mean to you - **Scout sign, salute, and handshake:** Understand when and how to use each one properly - **Patrol method:** Learn how Scouts work together in small groups - **Scout advancement:** Understand how you progress through ranks and earn merit badges - **Scout uniform:** Know how to wear your uniform properly with pride

Basic Skills - Knots: Show how to tie a square knot and two half-hitches - your first practical outdoor skills - **Pocketknife safety:** Demonstrate safe handling and the "blood circle" safety rule - **Citizenship:** Explain the Pledge of Allegiance and tell about the American flag - **Cyber safety:** Complete online training to learn safe internet practices

Scout Participation - Scoutmaster conference: A friendly one-on-one chat with your Scoutmaster about what you've learned - **Board of review:** Meet with adult leaders to share your Scout knowledge and experience

3.1.4 Requirements Process: How Advancement Works

- Initially, Scouts get their rank requirements signed off by more advanced Scouts
- Scouts should bring their Scout Handbook to meetings and outings for sign-offs
- Scout's name MUST be inside and outside their book
- Scouts need a pencil or pen and small notebook for taking notes and tracking progress
- Make photocopies or take pictures of completed pages every 2-3 months in case the book is lost
- Unlike in Cub Scouts, parents may not sign off on requirements

Important: Your Scout Handbook is your advancement record - take good care of it and keep it with you at meetings and activities!

3.1.5 Your Scout Family

During your first month, you'll meet the people who will support your Scouting journey:

Your Patrol Leader - An experienced Scout (usually 14-16 years old) who leads your patrol - Your primary mentor and guide during meetings and activities - Available to answer questions and help you learn Scout skills - Will work with you individually to help you complete Scout rank requirements

Your Scoutmaster - The adult leader who oversees the troop and your advancement - Will meet with you for your Scout rank Scoutmaster conference - Available to discuss your goals and help you succeed in Scouting - Responsible for ensuring you have a positive and safe Scouting experience

Merit Badge Counselors - Adult experts who will help you explore your interests through merit badges - Each counselor specializes in different subject areas - You'll work with them to complete merit badge requirements at your own pace

Your Scout Buddy - An experienced Scout assigned to help you during your first few months - Someone to sit with during meetings and help you feel included - Available to answer questions about troop procedures and activities

3.1.6 What You'll Accomplish

By the end of your first 30 days, you'll have:

Knowledge and Skills - Memorized the Scout Oath, Law, Motto, and Slogan - Learned basic Scout procedures and uniform standards - Mastered your first outdoor skills (knots and knife safety) - Completed cyber safety training - Understood how advancement works in Scouting

Achievement and Recognition - Earned your Scout rank - your first official milestone! - Received your Scout rank patch to wear on your uniform - Completed your first Scoutmaster conference and board of review - Set goals for your continued advancement toward Tenderfoot rank

3.2 Advancement to First Class

Welcome to your journey from Scout to First Class! This is where you'll learn the essential skills that will serve you throughout your entire Scouting adventure.

The advancement path is outlined in the Scout Handbook. Scouts can work on any requirement for Scout, Tenderfoot, Second Class or First Class (ST21) or merit badges at any time. However, they can only advance a rank when ALL requirements for that rank and lower are completed.

3.2.1 Your Journey: Scout to First Class

The ranks Scout → Tenderfoot → Second Class → First Class (ST21) teach you all the fundamental skills you'll need on your Scouting journey. While we encourage Scouts to work toward First Class within their first 18 months, this is a goal, not a requirement. Every Scout progresses at their own pace, and that's perfectly okay!

Skills You'll Master

Outdoor Skills - Camping and outdoor ethics (Leave No Trace principles) - Cooking skills and camp safety - First aid and emergency preparedness - Navigation using map and compass - Knots and rope work - Fire building and outdoor cooking - Weather awareness and preparation

Physical Fitness - Personal fitness planning and tracking - Swimming and water safety - Hiking and backpacking basics

Leadership and Citizenship - Leadership roles within your patrol - Community service projects - Citizenship and civic responsibility - Communication and teamwork skills

Why First Class matters: Scouts who earn First Class early in their Scouting journey are much more likely to stay in Scouting and eventually earn their Eagle Scout rank. These skills give you the confidence and ability to participate fully in all our outdoor adventures and leadership opportunities.

3.2.2 Timeline and Requirements Overview

- **Scout:** Your introduction to Scouting (first 30 days)
- **Tenderfoot:** Basic outdoor skills and Scout knowledge (typically 2-4 months after Scout)
- **Second Class:** Intermediate camping, cooking, and outdoor skills (typically 6-8 months after Scout)
- **First Class:** Advanced outdoor skills, leadership, and citizenship (typically 12-18 months after Scout)

Note: These are aspirational timelines. Every Scout progresses at their own pace based on their participation, effort, and opportunities to complete requirements.

3.2.3 Your Scouting Experience

3.2.4 Monthly Adventures: Campouts and Hiking

Every month, our troop goes on outdoor adventures designed to help you practice and advance your skills:

What to Expect - Learn and practice outdoor skills in real situations - Work on advancement requirements during activities - Build friendships with your patrol members - Gain confidence in outdoor settings - Have fun while learning!

Your Role - Come prepared with the right gear and attitude - Participate actively in patrol activities - Help with camp setup, cooking, and cleanup - Practice leadership when given opportunities - Support your fellow Scouts

3.2.5 Summer Camp: Your Big Adventure

Summer camp is a week-long experience that accelerates your advancement and skill development:

What You'll Do - Take merit badge classes in subjects that interest you - Participate in camp-wide activities and competitions - Practice outdoor skills in a focused environment - Meet Scouts from other troops - Experience more independence and responsibility

3.2.6 Service Projects: Giving Back

Service is a core part of Scouting, and you'll have many opportunities to help others through troop projects, community service, supporting Eagle Scout projects, environmental conservation, and helping with troop activities.

3.2.7 Leadership Development: Growing as a Leader

Patrol Leadership - Take turns serving as patrol leader or assistant patrol leader - Serve as grubmaster to plan meals and manage cooking responsibilities - Act as patrol quartermaster to organize and maintain patrol equipment - Help plan patrol activities and menus - Lead by example in your patrol - Support newer Scouts as they join

Troop Roles - Volunteer for troop positions as you gain experience - Help with setup and cleanup at meetings and events - Assist with teaching skills to other Scouts - Participate actively in troop meetings and activities

Leadership Skills You'll Develop - Communication and teamwork - Problem-solving and decision-making - Responsibility and accountability - Teaching and mentoring others (Scouting E.D.G.E. Method) - Planning and organization

3.2.8 Conferences and Reviews

- Every rank requires a Scoutmaster Conference
- Ranks beyond Scout Rank also require a Board of Review

Each rank advancement requires a board of review, where Scouts discuss their experiences and demonstrate their understanding of Scouting principles with adult leaders.

3.2.9 Merit Badge System

Merit badges are earned throughout your Scouting career and provide opportunities to explore interests and develop specialized skills. While not required for the First Class rank, merit badges complement your advancement journey.

Merit Badge Process - Talk to your Scoutmaster to get a blue card before starting any merit badge - Find counselors through our troop or the Lake Erie Council Merit Badge Counselor list - Work with merit badge counselors to complete requirements at your own pace - Complete requirements during troop meetings, camp, or individual study

Merit Badge Opportunities - Troop meetings and activities - Merit badge workshops at camps - Individual study with merit badge counselors - Community programs and classes - Merit badge universities - Summer camp programs

3.2.10 Merit Badge Documentation

- **Electronic Records:** We use Scoutbook.com requirements tracking.
- **Merit Badge Blue Cards:** Get one from your Scoutmaster before starting a new merit badge. Have three parts when used: one for troop, one for counselor, one for Scout.
- **Merit Badge Books:** Optional but helpful resources (now available online!)

Important for First Class Scouts: While merit badges aren't required for Scout through First Class ranks, earning merit badges during this period helps you explore interests and prepares you for Star rank, which requires 6 merit badges.

3.2.11 First Class Merit Badge Recommendations

Focus on merit badges that complement your rank advancement and can be worked on in parallel with rank requirements: - **Cooking:** Complements Second Class cooking requirements and is useful on every campout - **First Aid:** Complements First Class first aid requirements and teaches life-saving skills - **Swimming or Hiking:** Complements First Class fitness requirements and supports outdoor adventures - **Camping:** Complements camping skills learned in all ranks and enhances your outdoor experience

Popular Choices for New Scouts - Communications: Learn about different ways people communicate - **Family Life:** Explore family relationships and responsibilities - **Personal Fitness:** Develop healthy lifestyle habits - **Citizenship in the Community:** Learn about your local community and civic responsibility

More information: Scouting America Merit Badges

3.3 The Path to Eagle

The Eagle Scout rank is Scouting's highest achievement, representing years of growth, leadership, and service. After earning First Class, your Scouting journey shifts from learning basic skills to developing expertise, leadership, and making a lasting impact on your community.

3.3.1 The Journey: Star to Eagle

Star → Life → Eagle - Emphasis shifts to leadership, service, and personal growth - Merit badge requirements become more diverse and challenging - Leadership positions require greater responsibility and longer tenure - Community service hours increase significantly

3.3.2 Star Scout Requirements

Merit Badges: Earn 6 merit badges (4 must be from Eagle-required list) **Leadership:** Serve actively in a leadership position for 4 months **Service:** Complete 6 hours of community service **Skills:** Demonstrate Scout spirit and outdoor skills proficiency

3.3.3 Life Scout Requirements

Merit Badges: Earn 5 additional merit badges (3 must be from Eagle-required list) **Leadership:** Serve actively in a leadership position for 6 months **Service:** Complete 6 hours of community service **Skills:** Plan, develop, and lead a service project

3.3.4 Eagle Scout Requirements

3.3.5 Merit Badge Requirements

Total: 21 merit badges (including 13 specific Eagle-required badges)

Eagle-Required Merit Badges (All 13 Required): 1. **First Aid** - Emergency response and medical skills 2. **Citizenship in the Community** - Local civic engagement 3. **Citizenship in the Nation** - National civic responsibility 4. **Citizenship in the World** - Global awareness and responsibility 5. **Communication** - Written and verbal communication skills 6. **Personal Fitness** - Physical health and wellness 7. **Emergency Preparedness OR Lifesaving** - Crisis response skills 8. **Environmental Science OR Sustainability** - Environmental stewardship 9. **Personal Management** - Financial literacy and life skills 10. **Swimming OR Hiking OR Cycling** - Physical fitness activity 11. **Camping** - Advanced outdoor skills 12. **Cooking** - Food preparation and nutrition 13. **Family Life** - Relationship and family skills

Additional Merit Badges: 8 merit badges of your choice from any available options

3.3.6 Leadership Requirement

Position: Serve actively in a leadership position for 6 months, including: - Senior Patrol Leader - Assistant Senior Patrol Leader - Patrol Leader - Troop Guide - Order of the Arrow Representative - Den Chief - Scribe, Librarian, Historian, Quartermaster - Junior Assistant Scoutmaster - Chaplain Aide - Instructor - Webmaster - Leave No Trace Trainer - Outdoor Ethics Guide

3.3.7 Service Requirements

Community Service: Complete 6 hours of community service **Eagle Scout Service Project:** Plan, develop, and lead a service project that benefits a religious institution, school, or community organization (not Scouting)

3.3.8 The Eagle Scout Service Project

The Eagle project is the capstone of your Scouting experience and what often distinguishes Eagle Scouts as leaders throughout their lives.

3.3.9 Project Requirements

- **Benefits:** Must help a religious institution, school, or community organization (not a Scouting unit)
- **Leadership:** You must lead the project - others can help, but you're in charge
- **Planning:** Develop detailed project proposal, timeline, and budget
- **Approval:** Get approval from your troop, beneficiary, and council before starting
- **Documentation:** Keep detailed records of planning, execution, and results

3.3.10 Project Process

1. **Identify a Need:** Work with organizations to find meaningful projects
2. **Develop Your Proposal:** Create detailed plans, timelines, and resource requirements
3. **Get Approvals:** Present your proposal to troop committee, beneficiary, and council
4. **Execute Your Project:** Lead volunteers to complete the work
5. **Document Results:** Complete final reports and documentation

6. **Present to Board of Review:** Demonstrate your leadership and project impact

3.3.11 Project Ideas

- Build outdoor classrooms or gardens for schools
- Create accessibility improvements for community centers
- Develop educational trails or outdoor learning spaces
- Construct storage solutions for food banks or shelters
- Organize community resource fairs or educational programs
- Design and build playground equipment or outdoor fitness areas

3.3.12 Leadership Skills Developed

- **Project Management:** Planning, budgeting, scheduling, and execution
- **Team Leadership:** Motivating and directing volunteers
- **Communication:** Presenting ideas, writing proposals, and coordinating with organizations
- **Problem Solving:** Adapting to challenges and finding creative solutions
- **Service Leadership:** Understanding community needs and creating lasting impact

3.3.13 Beyond Eagle: Continuing Your Journey

3.3.14 Palms and Continued Recognition

- **Bronze Palm:** Earn 5 additional merit badges after Eagle
- **Gold Palm:** Earn 5 more merit badges (10 total after Eagle)
- **Silver Palm:** Earn 5 more merit badges (15 total after Eagle)
- Continue earning palms throughout your Scouting career

3.3.15 Advanced Scouting Programs

- **Venturing:** High adventure and specialized interests for ages 14-21
- **Sea Scouts:** Maritime adventures and skills for ages 14-21
- **Order of the Arrow:** Scouting's national honor society

3.3.16 College and Career Benefits

- **Scholarships:** Many Eagle Scout-specific scholarship opportunities
- **College Applications:** Eagle Scout recognition enhances applications
- **Career Advantages:** Leadership experience valued by employers
- **Networking:** Lifelong connections with fellow Eagle Scouts
- **Life Skills:** Project management, leadership, and service experience

3.3.17 Making Eagle Achievable

3.3.18 Start Early

- **Age 14:** Begin working on Eagle-required merit badges
- **Age 15-16:** Focus on leadership positions and advanced merit badges
- **Age 17:** Plan and execute Eagle project, complete final requirements
- **Age 18:** Final deadline - all requirements must be completed before 18th birthday

3.3.19 Stay Organized

- **Track Progress:** Use Scoutbook to monitor advancement
- **Plan Merit Badges:** Work on Eagle-required badges early
- **Document Service:** Keep records of all service hours
- **Seek Mentorship:** Work with Eagle Scouts and adult leaders

3.3.20 The Eagle Scout Legacy

Eagle Scout is more than a rank - it's a commitment to lifelong leadership and service. Eagle Scouts are found among leaders in every field: business, government, military, education, and community service.

Remember: Only about 4% of all Scouts earn Eagle Scout. It requires dedication, persistence, and commitment - but the rewards last a lifetime.

4 Leaders Guide

4.1 Adult Leadership Opportunities

4.1.1 What It Means to Be an Adult Leader in Troop 500

As an adult leader in our troop, you become part of the “Association with Adults” method - one of Scouting’s most powerful influences in youth development. In Troop 500, this means serving as a mentor, guide, and positive role model while supporting our Scout-led program.

Our adult leaders create safe, inclusive environments where Scouts can learn, grow, and lead. Whether you’re teaching outdoor skills, mentoring a Scout through advancement, or handling troop business behind the scenes, your role is to guide rather than direct - helping Scouts develop confidence and leadership skills by allowing them to make decisions, solve problems, and learn from their experiences.

Every adult leader in our troop commits to Scouting’s ideals and helps prepare our Scouts to become ethical leaders and engaged citizens in their communities.

4.1.2 Complete an Adult Leader Application

To become a registered adult leader, you’ll need to complete an adult leader application through BeAScout.scouting.org. This site will walk you through the registration process and help you get started with your leadership journey.

4.1.3 Exploring Your Options

Before committing to a specific role: - Talk with current leaders about their experiences - Shadow a leader at a meeting or outing - Consider what level of involvement works for your schedule - Connect with other parents in similar roles

4.1.4 Becoming Position Trained



When you take on a formal leadership role, completing both Safeguarding Youth and your position-specific training makes you “position trained.” Position trained leaders earn the distinctive trained patch (shown) which recognizes their commitment to providing quality Scouting experiences. This training ensures you have the knowledge and skills needed for your specific role in the troop.

4.1.5 Registered Adult Leader

- Registered adult leader who assists as needed
- Provides backup support for outings and activities
- Flexible involvement level based on your availability
- Good stepping stone to more involved leadership roles

4.1.6 Merit Badge Counselor

A merit badge counselor is a registered adult leader with knowledge and enthusiasm about a career, hobby or other subject who is willing to share that knowledge and enthusiasm with Scouts. As a merit badge counselor, you can: - Share your expertise by counseling Scouts in merit badges related to your profession or hobbies - Requires Safeguarding Youth Training and position-specific training - Flexible time commitment - work with individual Scouts or small groups - Great way to contribute without ongoing meeting attendance requirements

More information: Merit Badge Counselor Guide Find merit badge opportunities: Lake Erie Council Merit Badge Counselor List

4.1.7 Committee Member

The Troop Committee handles the business side of Scouting, allowing our Scoutmasters to focus on the youth program. Committee members typically commit to: - Attend monthly committee meetings (usually 1-2 hours, held on a weeknight) - Support one or more specialized areas based on your interests and skills - Help with planning and coordination behind the scenes - Assist with troop business and administrative functions

Committee Specialties Include:

- **Secretary:** Keep meeting minutes and maintain troop records
- **Treasurer:** Manage troop finances and track Scout accounts
- **Outdoor Activities Coordinator:** Plan and coordinate troop outings and special events
- **Advancement Coordinator:** Track Scout progress and coordinate boards of review
- **Chaplain:** Provides spiritual tone for troop meetings and activities
- **Training Coordinator:** Help adults complete required training
- **Equipment Coordinator:** Maintain and organize troop gear
- **Membership Coordinator:** Develop a plan for year-round membership flow into the troop

- **Others as needed:** Troops are encouraged to engage all parents in a role that suits their skills and interests.

4.1.8 Assistant Scoutmaster

- Work directly with youth leaders and patrols
- Attend regular troop meetings and outings
- Mentor youth in leadership development and outdoor skills
- Requires more comprehensive training including outdoor leader skills

4.1.9 Scoutmaster

- Primary youth program leader
- Responsible for overall program quality and youth development
- Requires extensive training and significant time commitment
- Mentors and guides all youth leaders in the troop

4.2 Adult Training Requirements



Adult leaders in Scouting America must complete required training to ensure the safety and quality of the program. Our troop is committed to having well-trained leaders who can provide the best possible experience for our Scouts.

4.2.1 Required Training for All Adult Leaders

Safeguarding Youth Training - Required for ALL adult leaders before they can participate in any Scouting activities - Must be renewed every three years - Online training available at my.scouting.org - Covers child abuse prevention and safe Scouting practices

Position-Specific Training Each adult leadership position has specific training requirements: - **Scoutmaster:** Scoutmaster Position-Specific Training - **Assistant Scoutmaster:** Assistant Scoutmaster Position-Specific Training - **Committee Chair:** Committee Chair Position-Specific Training - **Committee Members:** Committee Member Position-Specific Training - **Merit Badge Counselor:** Merit Badge Counselor Training

4.2.2 Additional Training

Outdoor Training - Hazardous Weather Training - This module will cover hazardous weather conditions that Scouts need to plan ahead and steps to take to be prepared. - Introduction to Outdoor Leader Skills (IOLS) - Working as patrols, this hands-on course provides adult leaders the practical outdoor skills they need to lead Scouts in the out-of-doors. Upon completion, leaders should feel comfortable teaching Scouts the basic skills required to obtain the First Class rank. Along with Scoutmaster Specifics this course is required of all direct contact leaders registered in Scouts BSA Troops in order to be considered “trained”.

(IOLS Information) - Wilderness First Aid - Recommended for outdoor activity leaders - Leave No Trace Trainer - Environmental stewardship training

Leadership Development - Wood Badge - Advanced leadership training for new and experienced leaders (Wood Badge Information) - University of Scouting - Council-sponsored training events - Scouting EDGE - The EDGE method is practiced throughout Scouting, and is Scouting's most effective training tool. Whether training Scout leaders in their position or teaching new outdoor skills to youth or new adult leaders, this training will give you the tools to keep your audience engaged while helping your instruction stick in their minds.

Event and Safety-Specific Training - Climb On Safely - For climbing and rappelling activities - Safety Afloat - For aquatic activities - Trek Safely - For hiking and backpacking - Shooting Sports Director Training - For firearms and archery programs

Getting Started with Training 1. Complete Safeguarding Youth Training (your first priority) 2. Register for Position-Specific Training (check with the Training Coordinator) 3. Plan for Outdoor Training if you'll be involved in outdoor activities 4. Consider Advanced Training like Wood Badge for leadership development

For training questions or assistance with registration, contact our Training Coordinator or visit the Lake Erie Council website.

4.2.3 Continual Training

Roundtable Once a month Scouting volunteers in a local community come together to provide information about local Scouting events, activities, and programs. Roundtables play a significant role in providing continuous supplemental training for unit leaders. This monthly event provides program topic guidance and structure suggestions for unit leaders. A fun environment creates excitement around the coming month of activities and program for unit leaders to carry back for implementation in their units. As an alternative or in addition to in-person Roundtables you can participate in virtual Roundtables.

University of Scouting / Pow Wow These opportunities may be available through your local council. Typically these are a series of courses that take place in one day and often provide the opportunity to take several sessions on various topics that help you provide a great program.

Remember: Every youth deserves a trained leader. Your commitment to training ensures we provide the highest quality Scouting program possible, and there's a place for every parent to contribute meaningfully to their Scout's experience.

5 Youth Leadership Development

Leadership development is a core component of the Scouting program. Youth leaders attend training opportunities and gain real-world experience managing troop activities, planning meetings, and mentoring younger Scouts.

5.1 Youth Leadership Training

5.1.1 Position-Specific Training

All youth leaders receive training specific to their position, including: - Leadership skills and techniques - Position-specific responsibilities and procedures - Communication and team-building skills - Problem-solving and decision-making

5.1.2 National Youth Leadership Training (NYLT)

NYLT is an exciting, action-packed program designed for Scouts who are ready to take the next step in their leadership development. This course teaches leadership skills and outdoor skills in an outdoor adventure setting.

5.2 Leadership in Action

Youth leaders apply their training through: - Leading troop meetings and activities - Planning and executing service projects - Mentoring younger Scouts - Representing the troop at district and council events

5.3 Adult Mentorship

Adult leaders provide guidance and support to youth leaders through: - Regular coaching and feedback - Modeling good leadership practices - Providing opportunities for growth and development - Supporting youth-led decision making

The combination of training, practical experience, and adult mentorship creates well-prepared leaders who are ready to succeed in Scouting and beyond.

6 Annual Planning

Troop 500G follows a structured annual planning cycle that keeps our program organized, Scout-led, and focused on delivering a quality Scouting experience throughout the year.

6.1 Elections and Leadership Transitions

6.1.1 Senior Patrol Leader Elections

The Senior Patrol Leader (SPL) is elected by the troop every six months. Candidates must meet the following eligibility requirements:

- Hold a rank of First Class or higher
- Have been active in a Scout troop for at least six months

6.1.2 Patrol and Troop Position Elections

Patrol Leaders are elected by their patrol members and other troop positions are appointed by the SPL with the advice and counsel of the Scoutmaster. Experienced Scouts holding a rank of First Class or higher, and having been active in a Scout troop for at least six months, will have an opportunity to run for patrol and troop positions.

Elections provide Scouts with real-world experience in democratic processes and give every eligible Scout the opportunity to serve in a leadership role.

6.2 Patrol Leaders' Council (PLC)

Those elected to leadership positions are expected to participate in Patrol Leaders' Conferences (PLC), which are held at least monthly. The PLC is the troop's planning and coordination body, led by the Senior Patrol Leader.

6.2.1 PLC Responsibilities

- Plan troop meetings and activities
- Coordinate the monthly outing calendar
- Discuss troop business and address concerns
- Plan service projects and special events
- Review and adjust the annual program plan

6.3 Annual Program Planning Conference

Each year, the troop holds an annual program planning conference where youth leaders — guided by adult mentors — build the troop's calendar for the coming year. This conference sets the direction for:

- Monthly camping trips and outings
- Merit badge opportunities and advancement activities
- Service projects and community involvement
- Special events, courts of honor, and celebrations
- Summer camp selection
- High adventure planning for eligible Scouts

6.4 Program Cycle Overview

Our troop program generally follows the Scouting year cycle:

- **Fall:** New year kickoff, recruitment, elections, and outdoor skill-building campouts
- **Winter:** Indoor skill sessions, winter camping, and merit badge focus
- **Spring:** Advancement push, service projects, and preparation for summer activities
- **Summer:** Summer camp, high adventure trips, and outdoor exploration

The specific calendar is planned annually by the Patrol Leaders' Council during the annual program planning conference. Check the events calendar and Scoutbook for the current schedule.

7 Outdoor Program

Our outdoor program is the heart of Troop 500G's activities, providing Scouts with opportunities to learn outdoor skills, experience adventure, and develop self-reliance.

7.1 Monthly Camping

We camp monthly, year-round, in all weather conditions. Our camping program includes:

- **Car camping** at established campgrounds
- **Backpacking** adventures
- **Winter camping** for cold-weather skills
- **High adventure** expeditions

7.2 Essential Gear

Every Scout should have their own basic camping equipment. See our Ten Essentials guide and Tent Camping List for detailed packing information.

7.3 Grubmaster Program

Our unique grubmaster system teaches Scouts meal planning, budgeting, and cooking skills. Each Scout takes turns being responsible for planning and preparing meals for the entire troop during camping trips.

Resources: - Grubmaster 101 - Basic meal planning - Grubmaster 201 - Advanced cooking techniques

7.4 High Adventure

Older Scouts have opportunities to participate in high adventure programs including: - Philmont Scout Ranch - Northern Tier Canoe Base - Florida Sea Base - Summit Bechtel Reserve

7.5 Leave No Trace

All outdoor activities follow Leave No Trace principles to minimize our environmental impact and preserve natural areas for future generations.

8 Accessibility and Inclusion

Scouting America is committed to making the Scouting program accessible to all youth, regardless of their abilities, backgrounds, or circumstances. Our troop embraces diversity and works to create an inclusive environment where every Scout can thrive and reach their full potential.

8.1 Our Commitment to Inclusion

At Troop 500G, we believe that Scouting is for everyone. We are dedicated to:

- **Welcoming all youth** who want to participate in Scouting, regardless of physical, cognitive, or developmental differences
- **Adapting activities** when necessary to ensure all Scouts can participate meaningfully
- **Creating supportive environments** where differences are celebrated and respected
- **Providing reasonable accommodations** to help Scouts overcome barriers to participation
- **Training our leaders** to understand and support Scouts with diverse needs

8.2 Scouting for Youth with Disabilities

Scouting America has a long history of serving youth with disabilities. We recognize that every Scout brings unique strengths and perspectives to the program. Our approach includes:

8.2.1 Individual Assessment

Each Scout's needs are assessed individually to determine appropriate accommodations and support strategies.

8.2.2 Flexible Programming

We adapt activities, requirements, and methods to ensure all Scouts can participate safely and successfully.

8.2.3 Inclusive Leadership

Our leaders are trained to create inclusive environments and work effectively with Scouts of all abilities.

8.2.4 Family Partnership

We work closely with families to understand each Scout's needs and develop appropriate support plans.

8.3 Accessibility Resources

8.3.1 Advancement Accommodations

Scouts with disabilities may be eligible for alternative requirements or methods to complete advancement. We work with the council advancement committee to ensure fair and appropriate accommodations.

8.3.2 Equipment and Facilities

We strive to ensure our meeting spaces and activities are accessible. When barriers exist, we work to find creative solutions.

8.3.3 Communication Support

We provide communication support as needed, including visual aids, interpreters, or alternative communication methods.

8.4 Creating an Inclusive Troop Culture

8.4.1 Respect and Understanding

- We promote respect for all individuals and celebrate diversity
- Scouts learn about different abilities and perspectives
- We address misconceptions and promote understanding

8.4.2 Buddy System

- We may pair Scouts to provide mutual support during activities
- Peer relationships help create natural inclusion opportunities

8.4.3 Flexible Participation

- Activities may be modified to ensure everyone can participate
- We focus on what Scouts CAN do, not what they cannot do

8.5 Support for Families

8.5.1 Open Communication

We maintain open dialogue with families about their Scout's needs, progress, and experiences.

8.5.2 Resource Sharing

We connect families with community resources and support networks when appropriate.

8.5.3 Advocacy

We advocate for our Scouts' needs within the broader Scouting community and help families navigate available resources.

8.6 Training and Development

8.6.1 Leader Training

Our adult leaders receive training on: - Understanding different types of disabilities - Appropriate language and interaction techniques - Activity modification strategies - Emergency procedures and safety considerations

8.6.2 Youth Education

Scouts learn about: - Respecting differences - Disability awareness - Inclusive leadership skills - How to be supportive patrol members

8.7 Getting Support

If you have questions about accessibility or inclusion in our troop, or if you need accommodations for your Scout, please contact:

- **Scoutmaster:** For program-related accommodations
- **Committee Chair:** For organizational support
- **Chartered Organization Representative:** For facility-related needs

8.8 Additional Resources

8.8.1 Scouting America Resources

- Accessibility and Inclusion Information Booklet - Download our comprehensive guide
- Council Accessibility Coordinator
- National Accessibility and Inclusion resources

8.8.2 Community Resources

- Local disability service organizations
- Educational support services
- Healthcare professionals
- Therapeutic recreation programs

8.9 Contact Information

For specific questions about accessibility accommodations or to discuss your Scout's individual needs, please reach out to our leadership team. We are committed to working with every family to ensure their Scout has a positive and successful Scouting experience.

Every Scout deserves the opportunity to experience the adventure, friendship, and character development that Scouting offers. We are here to make that possible for all youth in our community.

9 Conference Communications

Building strong relationships between families and troop leadership is essential for every Scout's success. Troop 500G uses structured conferences to ensure open communication, understand each Scout's unique needs, and create supportive partnerships between parents and leaders.

9.1 Joining Conference

Every new Scout family is required to participate in a joining conference with troop leadership before their Scout's first overnight camping experience. This is a foundational element of our welcoming and inclusive approach to Scouting.

9.1.1 Purpose and Benefits

The joining conference builds trust and rapport between parents and leaders as partners in delivering the Scouting program. It helps us understand each Scout's unique strengths, interests, and any special considerations that will help ensure their success in our program.

Key Benefits: - Establishes open communication between families and leadership - Helps leaders understand each Scout's individual strengths and needs - Creates a supportive environment where every Scout can thrive - Builds trust and partnership between parents and troop leadership - Provides opportunity to discuss concerns or accommodations - Sets expectations for ongoing communication

9.1.2 When and Where

- **Timing:** Scheduled within the first month after joining the troop
- **Location:** Private setting away from other members to ensure confidential conversation
- **Duration:** Typically 30-45 minutes, depending on discussion needs

9.1.3 Who Attends

Required Attendees: - One or both parents/guardians - Scoutmaster or designated troop leadership - Assistant Scoutmaster or other key leader who will work directly with the Scout

Optional Attendees: - The Scout (depending on age, maturity, and family preference) - Additional family members if desired

9.1.4 Conference Topics

The joining conference is a friendly, informative, get-to-know-you meeting focused on understanding your Scout. We encourage open and honest discussion about:

Strengths and Interests - What are your Scout's unique strengths and talents? - What activities or subjects particularly interest them? - What motivates and excites them about Scouting?

Learning and Communication Style - How does your Scout learn best? - Are there any concerns with reading, writing, or comprehension? - What communication approaches work well at home or school?

Social and Emotional Considerations - How does your Scout interact in group settings? - Are there any triggers for emotional or behavioral challenges? - What are the warning signs when your Scout feels overwhelmed? - What strategies help when they're struggling?

Accommodations and Support - Are there any accommodations made at home or school? - What helps your Scout be successful in new environments? - Are there any safety considerations we should know about? - What concerns do you have about your Scout participating in Scouting activities?

Family Expectations and Goals - What do you hope your Scout will gain from Scouting? - How can we best communicate with your family? - What level of involvement would you like in troop activities?

9.1.5 Confidentiality and Information Sharing

Your Privacy is Protected: - Parents decide what information to share with leaders - All information is assumed confidential unless you give permission to share - We may ask permission to share relevant information with other key leaders who work with your Scout - Information is only shared on a need-to-know basis to support your Scout's success

Building Your Team: The goal is to form a partnership with parents to provide the best possible Scouting experience for your Scout while respecting your family's privacy and preferences.

9.2 Support Conference

A Support Conference is an as-needed meeting between parents and leadership to address specific situations, plan for special events, or reassess a Scout's needs. These conferences ensure ongoing communication and support throughout your Scout's journey in our troop.

9.2.1 When Support Conferences are Held

Event-Specific Situations: - Before major camping trips, summer camp, or high adventure activities - When leaders need additional information for specific events or activities - Before participation in activities that may present unique challenges

Ongoing Support Needs: - When a Scout's needs or circumstances change - If behavioral or participation concerns arise - When parents request additional support or have new concerns - Following significant life changes (family situations, medical changes, etc.)

Success Planning: - To celebrate progress and discuss next steps - When considering leadership positions or advanced opportunities - To plan strategies for challenging advancement requirements

9.2.2 Support Conference Process

Initiated By: - Parents who have concerns or questions - Leadership when additional support may be beneficial - The Scout themselves (for older Scouts)

Format: - Similar to joining conference but focused on specific situations - Can be conducted in person, over phone, or via video call - May involve additional specialists (camp staff, merit badge counselors, etc.)

Follow-Up: - Clear action items and next steps - Timeline for checking in again if needed - Documentation of agreements or accommodations

9.3 Conference Best Practices

9.3.1 For Parents

Come Prepared: - Think about your Scout's current needs and any changes since the last conference - Bring specific examples of what works well and what challenges exist - Consider your questions and concerns ahead of time

Be Open and Honest: - Share information that helps leaders support your Scout - Discuss both strengths and challenges - Ask questions about anything you don't understand

Think Partnership: - Work together with leaders to develop strategies - Be open to suggestions and new approaches - Maintain ongoing communication between formal conferences

9.3.2 For Leaders

Create a Welcoming Environment: - Ensure privacy and confidentiality - Use active listening skills - Ask open-ended questions - Avoid making assumptions or judgments

Focus on the Scout's Success: - Emphasize strengths and positive attributes - Collaborate on solutions for challenges - Respect family decisions and privacy - Follow through on commitments made

Maintain Professional Standards: - Respect confidentiality guidelines - Document important information appropriately - Seek additional training or resources when needed - Know when to refer families to other resources

9.4 Ongoing Communication

Conferences are just one part of maintaining strong family-troop relationships:

Regular Check-Ins: - Informal conversations at meetings and events - Email or phone communication as needed - Annual review meetings for ongoing participants

Open Door Policy: - Parents are always welcome to request additional conferences - Leaders will proactively suggest conferences when beneficial - No concern is too small to discuss

Building Community: - Conferences help create an inclusive, supportive troop environment - Understanding each Scout helps leaders better serve all Scouts - Strong family partnerships strengthen the entire troop program

9.5 Resources and Support

Troop Leadership: Our trained leaders are here to support every Scout and family. Don't hesitate to reach out with questions or concerns.

Council Resources: - Lake Erie Council Disabilities Awareness Committee - Special needs resources and training - Professional Scouting staff consultation

Additional Information: - Scouting America Diversity Resources - Guide to Safe Scouting

Remember: Every Scout brings unique strengths to our troop. Through open communication and strong partnerships with families, we create an environment where every Scout can thrive and reach their full potential in Scouting.

10 Policies & Safety

Safety is our top priority in all troop activities. We follow Scouting America's Guide to Safe Scouting and maintain additional troop-specific policies.

10.1 Youth Protection / Safeguarding Youth

All adult leaders complete Youth Protection Training before participating in troop activities. We maintain two-deep leadership on all activities and follow all Youth Protection guidelines.

For more information, visit: [Scouting America Youth Protection](#)

10.1.1 Youth Protection Training Requirements

All scout leaders are trained and certified in the Youth Protection program through Scouting America. Scout parents are also required to complete a Youth Protection exercise with their daughter and submit documentation to the troop.

10.1.2 Two Deep Leadership

To ensure the safety of all scouts, Scouting America requires "Two Deep Leadership" - at least two adults must be present for any scouting activity. This is especially essential during outings, summer camp, and high adventure activities. To achieve this level of safety, parents must take an active part in the operations and activities of the troop.

10.1.3 Mandatory Report of Child Abuse

All persons involved in Scouting shall report to local authorities any good-faith suspicion or belief that any child is or has been physically or sexually abused, physically or emotionally neglected, exposed to any form of violence or threat, exposed to any form of sexual exploitation, including the possession, manufacture, or distribution of child pornography, online solicitation, enticement, or showing of obscene material. You may not abdicate this reporting responsibility to any other person.

10.1.4 Scouts First Helpline

As part of its "Scouts First" approach to the protection and safety of youth, Scouting America has established a dedicated 24-hour helpline to receive reports of known or suspected abuse or behavior that might put a

youth at risk. 1-844-SCOUTS1 (1-844-726-8871) If immediate assistance is needed in the handling of a sexual abuse allegation, contact Scouts First Helpline (1-844-SCOUTS1). If someone is at immediate risk of harm, always call 911.

10.2 Medical Information

All participants must have current medical forms on file: - **Parts A & B:** Required for all activities - **Part C:** Required for camping and high adventure

Medical forms must be updated annually or when medical conditions change.

For current medical forms and requirements, visit: [Scouting America Health and Safety](#)

10.3 Activity Safety

- All outdoor activities include safety briefings
- Proper safety equipment is required for all activities
- Weather conditions are monitored and activities modified as needed
- Emergency action plans are in place for all activities

10.4 Financial Policies

10.4.1 Troop Fees

- Annual registration fees cover troop insurance and Scouting America registration
- Activity fees cover specific trip costs and are collected in advance
- Equipment fees may apply for specialized gear rental

10.4.2 Fundraising

The troop participates in fundraising activities to help offset program costs and support Scouts who need financial assistance.

10.4.3 Financial Assistance

Financial assistance is available for Scouts who need help with fees or equipment costs. Contact the Scoutmaster confidentially to discuss options.

10.5 Code of Conduct

All troop members are expected to follow the Scout Oath and Law in their behavior during troop activities and in their daily lives.

11 Resources & Equipment

11.1 Personal Equipment

Scouts are responsible for acquiring and maintaining their own personal camping equipment. Essential items include:

- A Daypack with the Ten Essentials
- Sleeping bag and pad
- Mess Kit
- Backpack / Duffle Bag
- Personal camping items

See our Tent Camping List for complete packing guidance.

11.2 Troop Equipment

The troop maintains a variety of equipment available for Scout use:

11.2.1 Camping Equipment

- Tents and tarps
- Cooking stoves and fuel
- First aid supplies
- Patrol cooking equipment

11.2.2 Activity Equipment

- Game and activity supplies
- Merit badge materials
- Ceremonial items

View our complete equipment inventory in the Files section.

11.3 Equipment Maintenance

Regular maintenance of troop equipment is essential for safety and longevity. Scouts participate in equipment maintenance as part of their service hours and skill development.

See our Troop Gear Maintenance guide for detailed maintenance procedures.

11.4 Duty Roster

All troop members participate in setup, cleanup, and maintenance activities through our duty roster system. This teaches responsibility and ensures that everyone contributes to troop operations.

11.5 Grubmaster Resources

Our grubmaster program includes comprehensive resources for meal planning and outdoor cooking:

- Grubmaster 101 - Introduction to meal planning and basic cooking
- Grubmaster 201 - Advanced techniques and menu ideas

12 Useful Links

Here are some valuable online resources to support your Scouting journey and help you make the most of your experience in Troop 500G.

12.1 Official Scouting America Resources

12.1.1 Scouting.org

The official Scouting America website with comprehensive information about programs, policies, resources, and news. Essential for staying current with Scouting updates and accessing official materials.

12.1.2 Be a Scout

The official resource for new families and potential Scouts. Learn about Scouting programs, find local units, and discover what makes Scouting special.

12.1.3 Scouts BSA Resources

Official resources specifically for Scouts BSA participants, including advancement information, activity guides, forms, and program materials.

12.2 Scout Life and Inspiration

12.2.1 Scout Life Magazine

The official magazine of Scouting America featuring outdoor adventure stories, Scouting news, advancement tips, games, and inspiring stories from Scouts across the country.

12.2.2 Scouting America YouTube Channel

Official video content including outdoor skills tutorials, advancement guidance, inspiring Scout stories, and program information to enhance your Scouting experience.

12.2.3 TroopLeader Online

Comprehensive digital resource hub for Scouts, families, and Scouters featuring advancement tracking, leadership position guides, troop structure information, and practical resources for all aspects of the Scouting program.

12.3 Local Resources

12.3.1 Lake Erie Council

Our local Scout council serving Northeast Ohio. Find council-wide events, training schedules, camp information, forms, and local Scouting news. Essential for staying connected with the broader Scouting community in our region.

12.3.2 Scout Shop - Lake Erie Council

Official Scout Shop at Lake Erie Council Headquarters (2241 Woodland Ave, Cleveland, Ohio) for purchasing uniforms, badges, handbooks, and other Scouting gear.

12.3.3 Scout Shop - Great Trail Council

Alternative Scout Shop serving Northeast Ohio, providing uniforms, patches, handbooks, camping gear, and other official Scouting merchandise.

12.4 Getting the Most from These Resources

For New Scouts: - Start with Be a Scout to understand the basics - Explore Scout Life Magazine for fun activities and inspiration - Watch YouTube videos to see Scouting skills in action

For Advancing Scouts: - Use Scouts BSA Resources for advancement requirements - Explore TroopLeader Online for leadership position guides and troop structure - Check Scouting.org for the latest program updates - Follow Scout Life for outdoor adventure ideas and leadership tips

For Parents: - Visit Scouting.org for parent resources and volunteer opportunities - Check Lake Erie Council for training schedules and local events - Explore Be a Scout to understand the full Scouting program - Use these resources to support your Scout's advancement journey

12.5 Stay Connected

These links are great starting points, but remember that your local Troop 500G community is your primary resource. Don't hesitate to ask your patrol leaders, adult leaders, or fellow Scouts for guidance and support!

For the most current links and additional resources, visit our troop website at troop500.org

Troop Contact Information

12.6 Chartered Organization



12.6.1 Chartered Organization Representative: Anthony Binkowsky

Phone: [Contact through charter organization]

Email: [Contact through charter organization]

12.7 Scoutmasters



12.7.1 Scoutmaster: Jenni Ferro

Phone: 917-658-3022

Email: jcelia@hotmail.com



12.7.2 Assistant Scoutmaster: Ryan May

Phone: 216-385-5341

Email: spockmay@gmail.com

**12.7.3 Assistant Scoutmaster: Shari Armstrong**

Phone: 216-650-3059

Email: shari.l.armstrong@gmail.com

**12.7.4 Assistant Scoutmaster: Arunkumar Srinivasan**

Phone: 614-216-2519

Email: mrarunks@yahoo.com

12.8 Troop Committee**12.8.1 Committee Chair: Heather Gansler**

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: heatherlgee@gmail.com

12.8.2 Scribe / Records Coordinator: Vickie Schroeder

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: [To be updated]

12.8.3 Treasurer: Renee Kirbawy

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: [To be updated]

12.8.4 New Member Coordinator: Nick Kelley

Phone: 330-979-8897

Email: Nick.Kelley@att.net

12.8.5 Advancement Coordinator: Doug Gansler

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: doug.gansler@gmail.com

**12.8.6 Equipment Coordinator: Corey Murphy**

Phone: 814-573-2304

Email: c.murphy360@gmail.com

12.8.7 Special Events / Service Project Coordinator: Vacant

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: [To be updated]

12.8.8 Fundraising Coordinator: Vacant

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: [To be updated]

12.8.9 Recruitment Coordinator: Vacant

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: [To be updated]

12.8.10 New Family Guide: Vacant

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: [To be updated]

**12.8.11 Webmaster: Ryan May**

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: [To be updated]

12.8.12 Outdoor Chair: Arunkumar Srinivasan

Phone: 614-216-2519

Email: mrarunks@yahoo.com

12.8.13 Mid-Adventure Coordinator: Arunkumar Srinivasan, Jim Stoddard-Dare

Phone: [Contact through Outdoor Chair]

Email: thedarefamily2003@gmail.com

12.8.14 High Adventure Coordinator: Arunkumar Srinivasan, Jim Stoddard-Dare

Phone: [Contact through Outdoor Chair]

Email: thedarefamily2003@gmail.com

12.8.15 Eagle Scout Coordinator: Steve Herman, Nirav Vora

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: [To be updated]

**12.8.16 Troop Librarian and Historian: Vacant**

Phone: [To be updated]

Email: [To be updated]

12.8.17 General Contact

For questions about the troop or this handbook: - Attend any weekly meeting (Monday evenings at Advent Lutheran Church) - Contact the Scoutmaster or New Member Coordinator - Visit our website at troop500.org

12.8.18 Communication

GroupMe Groups We communicate via GroupMe with separate groups for adults and Scouts. Contact the Scoutmaster or committee members to be added to the appropriate groups. All Scout communication groups are monitored by two-deep adult leadership to ensure safety.

Two-Deep Communication Policy Whenever there is any online, text, virtual, or phone communication between a Scout and an adult, there must always be two adults participating in the communication, maintaining our two-deep leadership standard.

Ready to start your Scouting adventure? Let's explore what Troop 500G has to offer!

12.9 Appendix

12.9.1 Appendix A: Joining Conference Template

Appendix A: Joining Conference

12.10 Overview

Every Scout who joins Troop 500G brings their own unique strengths, interests, and needs — and this conference is our chance to learn about yours. By taking a little time to talk before your Scout's first campout, we can make sure our leaders are prepared to support them from day one. This form is a guide for that conversation, not an evaluation — there are no wrong answers, and you are always welcome to leave any question blank. Everything shared here stays confidential within our leadership team and is used only to help your Scout thrive.

12.10.1 A Note About Scout Leadership

Troop 500G leaders are volunteers — mostly parents who care deeply about Scouts and want to help. We attend a lot of training, but we also have full-time jobs and busy lives. Sometimes we miss details or make mistakes, but our goal is always to support your Scout and help them succeed. Just as Scouts “Do their best,” we do too. If you ever have concerns or questions, please talk to us. We'll figure it out together!

12.10.2 A Conversation Guide

The Lake Erie Council Accessibility and Inclusion Committee encourages Units to hold joining conferences with every incoming Scout. These meetings are between leaders (often Scoutmasters, Assistant Scoutmasters, and New Member Coordinators), parents, and Scouts. Joining meetings encourage inclusive, strengths-based conversations to better understand and support each Scout's unique needs. The conference should take place within the first month after a Scout joins, and is designed to build partnerships with families rather than evaluate suitability.

12.10.3 Inclusive

Joining conferences are held for every Scout, recognizing that all Scouts have unique needs and strengths. Some may require additional support, but every Scout benefits from understanding and partnership.

12.10.4 Confidentiality & Privacy

The goal of joining conferences is to provide leaders enough information to support Scouts during camping and troop activities. While confidentiality is important, we ask that parents and guardians share enough information with our trained leaders to help their Scout succeed. Required Annual Health and Medical Forms store private medical information and are not authorized for digital storage. All joining conference information is stored in Troop 500G Google Drive, with access limited to adult troop leaders who need it to

provide support to your Scout. If you have privacy concerns, please let us know. You may leave any fields blank if you prefer not to share certain information. All details discussed are kept confidential unless explicit permission is given to share with other leaders.

12.10.5 You're part of the team

Leaders, parents, and Scouts work together as a team, and the goal is a supportive partnership where every Scout can thrive. Open communication is essential — if something is worrying you, please say so. If something is unclear, just ask. We would rather hear about a concern early than have a Scout struggle in silence.

12.10.6 Strengths-Based

Every Scout brings their own unique strengths, talents, and interests. The joining conference focuses on identifying and building upon these strengths, helping Scouts feel confident and valued in the troop. That said, building on strengths is most effective when leaders also understand where a Scout might struggle — knowing potential challenges helps us provide the right support before small difficulties become bigger ones.

12.10.7 No Diagnosis Required

The conversation is about what helps the Scout succeed — not about medical diagnoses or labels. Families are encouraged to share strategies, preferences, and needs, regardless of whether there is a formal diagnosis.

12.10.8 Conducted Post-Joining

The joining conference is held after the Scout has joined the troop. It is not an evaluation or selection process, but a way to welcome the Scout and ensure they have the support they need from the start.

12.10.9 An Ongoing Conversation

The joining conference is just the beginning of a supportive relationship. Scouts, parents, and leaders all grow and change, and so do their needs. Any leader, Scout, or parent may request another conference at any time to revisit goals, address new challenges, or update support strategies. We especially encourage a follow-up conference with leaders and families before Scouts attend summer camp, to ensure everyone is prepared and supported for new experiences.

12.11 Pre-Meeting Checklist

This section is to be completed by troop leadership prior to the Joining Conference.

- ☐ Scout has joined the Troop (*beascout.scouting.org*)
- ☐ Private, confidential meeting space arranged (*out of earshot of others*)
- ☐ At least one disability-awareness trained leader present if possible
- ☐ Family understands this is about understanding their Scout, not evaluation
- ☐ Troop 500G Handbook (*Printed Hardcopy*)
- ☐ Below form has been sent to family for review

12.12 Scout Contact Information

Scout Name: _____ Age: _____

Birthday: _____ Grade: _____

School: _____

Phone: _____ Scout's Phone: _____

Email: _____

Address: _____

Scouting.org Member ID: _____

Siblings: _____

Sibling Scouting involvement: _____

12.12.1 Emergency Contact

Who should we contact if parent(s)/guardian(s) are unavailable?

Name: _____ Relationship: _____

Phone: _____

12.12.2 Onboarding Checklist

- ☐ Annual Health and Medical Record A & B (*C before summer camp*)
- ☐ IEP / 504 (*As Needed*)
- ☐ Social Media Waiver
- ☐ Access to GroupMe
- ☐ Access to Troop 500 Google Calendar

12.13 Parent / Guardian 1 Contact Information

Name: _____

Relationship to Scout: _____

Phone: _____ Secondary Phone: _____

Email: _____

Address: _____

Scouting.org Member ID: _____

Previous Scouting Experience: _____

12.13.1 Onboarding Checklist

- ☐ Reviewed Safe Scouting Pamphlet with Scout
- ☐ Youth Protection Training Complete
- ☐ Access to GroupMe
- ☐ Access to Troop 500 Google Calendar
- ☐ Annual Health and Medical Record *As Needed*

12.13.2 How would you like to help?

- ☐ I would like to focus on my Scout for now!
- ☐ I can help with small side-tasks and events!
- ☐ Scouter Reserve, able to attend some campouts (Registration Required)
- ☐ Committee member (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Assistant Scoutmaster, Planning Campouts/Events (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Merit badge counselor (Registration / Training Required)

12.13.3 Skills, Interests or Resources

What do you know, or are good at that you want to share? _____

12.14 Parent / Guardian 2 Contact Information

Name: _____

Relationship to Scout: _____

Phone: _____ Secondary Phone: _____

Email: _____

Address: _____

Scouting.org Member ID: _____

Previous Scouting Experience: _____

12.14.1 Onboarding Checklist

- ☐ Reviewed Safe Scouting Pamphlet with Scout
- ☐ Youth Protection Training Complete
- ☐ Access to GroupMe
- ☐ Access to Troop 500 Google Calendar
- ☐ Annual Health and Medical Record *As Needed*

12.14.2 How would you like to help?

- ☐ I would like to focus on my Scout for now!
- ☐ I can help with small side-tasks and events!
- ☐ Scouter Reserve, able to attend some campouts (Registration Required)
- ☐ Committee member (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Assistant Scoutmaster, Planning Campouts/Events (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Merit badge counselor (Registration / Training Required)

12.14.3 Skills, Interests or Resources

What do you know, or are good at that you want to share? _____

12.15 About Your Scout

12.15.1 Scouting Experience

Previous Scouting Experience: _____

Why did your Scout want to join our troop? _____

Does your Scout like to camp? _____

Do you consider your Scout a swimmer? _____

What is your Scout's goal in Scouting? _____

12.15.2 Strengths & Interests

What are your Scout's unique strengths? _____

What does your Scout enjoy most? What are they passionate about? _____

What makes them feel successful and confident? _____

Hobbies: _____

12.15.3 Allergies / Dietary Considerations

Allergies: _____

Dietary restrictions: _____

Is your Scout a picky eater? What foods will they eat, and what do they refuse or strongly dislike?

12.15.4 Medical, Physical, & Sensory Considerations

Any physical limitations or accommodations needed? _____

Any Medical conditions we should be aware of? (Details in AHMR) _____

Can your Scout take pills? _____

Is your Scout prepared for her period? _____

Bedtime and sleep routines (*important for overnight and camping trips*):

- Regular bedtime: _____
- Bedtime routine or needs: _____
- Sleep concerns (*sleepwalking, nightmares, sleep aids, etc.*): _____

Sensory sensitivities? (loud noises, bright lights, textures, crowds, etc.) _____

What happens if your Scout misses meds? _____

12.15.5 Learning & Communication Style

How does your Scout learn best? (visual, hands-on, verbal instructions, etc.) _____

Are there any concerns with reading, writing, or comprehension? _____

What strategies work well at home or school to help them learn? _____

12.15.6 Social & Emotional Needs

How does your Scout handle new situations or changes to routine? _____

What helps them be successful in small or large group settings? _____

Does anything trigger anxiety, overwhelm, or emotional struggles? _____

What are the warning signs when they're becoming overwhelmed? _____

What strategies help when they're struggling? How can we help them succeed? _____

12.15.7 Previous Experiences & Concerns

What accommodations or adaptations are made at home and school? _____

What concerns do you have about your Scout's participation in Scouting? _____

Any previous challenges with group activities or programs? _____

12.15.8 Family Considerations

This information is kept strictly confidential and used only to ensure your Scout's safety and success.

Any family needs, situations, or custody arrangements we should be aware of?

(e.g., who may pick up the Scout, communication preferences between households, court orders, etc.)

Who is authorized to pick up the Scout? _____

Anyone who is NOT authorized to pick up the Scout? _____

12.16 Support Strategies & Action Planning

12.16.1 What Works for Your Scout?

Strategies that help them succeed: _____

What should we make sure to do for your Scout? _____

What should we avoid doing or be careful about? _____

When they're struggling, how do you help them? How can we help? _____

What else should we know or talk about?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins or other markings on the paper.

12.18 Conference Summary

To be filled out by Troop Leadership during the Joining Conference.

12.18.1 Main Concerns

- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____

Scout's key strengths to build upon: _____

Primary support strategies identified: _____

Accommodations/adaptations to implement: _____

12.18.2 Troop Integration Plan

- ☐ Patrol Assigned: _____
- ☐ Scout Buddy Assigned: _____
- ☐ Parent(s)/Guardian(s) added to GroupMe
- ☐ Scout added to GroupMe
- ☐ Parent(s)/Guardian(s) can access Troop Calendar
- ☐ Scout can access Troop Calendar
- ☐ Check in after first campout (*Scoutmaster Conference*)
- ☐ Check in conference before summer camp?
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

Scoutmaster Signature: _____ Date: _____

Assistant Scoutmaster Signature: _____ Date: _____

Parent/Guardian Signature: _____ Date: _____

Parent/Guardian Signature: _____ Date: _____

File Location: Troop 500G Google Drive: _____

Download this template as PDF: [Joining Conference Template \(PDF\)](#)